

INFORMS 2026 DMS Data Challenge: Evaluation Procedure

Metric: Root Mean Squared Error (RMSE). Computed separately for each of the four forecast horizons, pooled across all 63 test counties and all valid rows:

$$\text{RMSE}_k = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N_k} \sum_{i,t} (\hat{y}_{i,t+k} - y_{i,t+k})^2} \quad k \in \{1, 6, 24, 48\} \text{ hours}$$

where $i \in \{1, \dots, 63\}$ indexes the test counties, t indexes each hour in the March 14–19 prediction window, and N_k is the total number of valid (non-NaN) county-hour pairs for horizon k .

Ranking. Teams are ranked within each horizon (rank 1 = lowest RMSE). Overall ranking = average rank across the four horizons. Ties broken by t+1h RMSE.

Finalists. The top 3 teams by combined numerical performance and written report quality are invited to present at the DMDA workshop. Final prize order is determined by the judging panel based on the oral presentation.

Target	Horizon	Scoreable rows
osi_target_t01h	$t + 1\text{h}$	9,009
osi_target_t06h	$t + 6\text{h}$	8,694
osi_target_t24h	$t + 24\text{h}$	7,560
osi_target_t48h	$t + 48\text{h}$	6,048